Practical 8

MENTAL STATUS EXAMINATION

Introduction

The mental status examination is the part of the clinical assessment that describes the sum total of examiner's observation and impressing of the psychiatric patient at the time of interview, whereas the patient's history remains stable. The patient's mental status can change from day to day or hour to hour. Even when a patient is mute or refuses to answer questions, the clinician can obtain a wealth information through careful observation.

MSE is developed by philosopher and psychiatrist Karl Jaspers.

Definition

The mental status examination (MSE) is a cross-sectional, systemic documentation of the quality of mental functioning at the time of interview.

The mental status examination is the part of the clinical assessment that describes the sum total of the examiner's observations and impressions of the psychiatric patient at the time of the interview.

Purpose

1. To make an accurate diagnosis and formulation
2. To plan for the treatment
3. To obtain evidence of symptoms and signs of mental disorders, including danger to self and others that are present at the time of interview

Precautions

The MSE cannot be given to patient

1. Who cannot pay attention to the examiner for example coma or unconscious
2. Completely unable to speak (aphasic)
3. Not fluent in the language of the examiner

Description

General appearance and Behavior

The examiner notes the person's age, sex and overall appearance. These features are significant because poor personal hygiene or grooming may reflect a loss of interest in self care or physical inability to bathe or dress oneself.

Appearance	:	Apparent to age/ older than age
Grooming	:	Normally/abnormally dressed
Cleanliness	:	Adequate / inadequate
Mode of entry	:	Willingly came / brought by force
Rapport	:	Spontaneous / not established
Facial expression	:	Happy / Sad / Anger / Cannot be described
Posture	:	Relaxed / Changing posture

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